

Responding to Hybrid Cyber-Influence Operations and Information Manipulation: Countermeasures, Frameworks, and the 2×2 Matrix

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Covering: Q7a (Elite responses to hybrid cyber/influence ops) and Q7b (Community responses to information manipulation causing real harm), with a 2×2 analytical matrix

Executive Summary

No single countermeasure adequately addresses the full spectrum of hybrid threats analysed in this research series. Instead, the response landscape must be understood as a portfolio: technical tools for elites with high digital capability; legal and regulatory tools requiring regional cooperation; resilience-building tools requiring sustained investment in communities; and trust-based interventions engaging the social fabric where purely digital remedies cannot reach. The EEAS 4th FIMI Report (March 2026) identifies hybridisation, AI-enabled operations, and increased covertness as the three principal trends of 2025, and explicitly shifts European strategy from reactive detection to proactive deterrence — "blowing the house of cards down" by targeting the key enablers, intermediaries, and service providers that sustain hostile operations. The Accra Declaration (October 2024), by contrast, reflects the very different priorities of African information integrity professionals: digital literacy, community resilience, linguistic diversity, offline tool-kits, and multi-stakeholder coalitions. These two documents together frame the fundamental challenge: the Global North has sophisticated digital countermeasures against sophisticated state-level intrusion-based operations; Africa has community-based resilience initiatives against a sprawling ecosystem of locally-generated and externally-amplified harm that reaches populations with no internet connection. The section on practical steps is structured around a 2×2 matrix — **Elite vs. Ordinary × High Information Access vs. Low Information Access** — to make this contextual gap actionable.^{[1][2]}

Part 7a: Responses to Hybrid Cyber-Influence Operations (Elite-Focused)

Strict Definition: Responses to Intrusion-Based Hybrid Operations

These are operations combining an unauthorised cyber intrusion with an influence goal — hack-and-leak campaigns, ransomware-as-reputational-blackmail, infrastructure sabotage paired with narrative operations, and implant-enabled disinformation. The threat actors are primarily nation-states (GRU, SVR, IRGC, PLA-SSF), their proxies, and criminal groups working on behalf of or alongside states.

Multilateral and Intergovernmental Responses

The most institutionally mature responses to intrusion-based hybrid operations are concentrated in Europe and the transatlantic security community. The EEAS StratCom division, established in 2015 initially to counter Russian disinformation targeting Ukraine, has evolved into a sophisticated FIMI detection and deterrence architecture. Its 4th Annual FIMI Threat Report (2026) identified 540 incidents in 2025, with 10,500 social media channels and websites mobilised to produce or amplify FIMI. The report introduces a "FIMI Deterrence Playbook" — a structural shift from reactive analysis to proactive targeting of critical nodes in the FIMI infrastructure: intermediaries, hosting providers, advertising networks, and the proxies that provide plausible deniability.^{[3][2]}

NATO's CCDCOE (Cooperative Cyber Defence Centre of Excellence) in Tallinn has published frameworks for understanding how cyber operations intersect with influence, including the legally significant Tallinn Manual 2.0. NATO's StratCom Centre of Excellence in Riga operates separately, focusing specifically on the influence side of hybrid threats. The 2025 Recorded Future threat assessment on the NATO Summit in The Hague identified Russian hybrid threats as "highly likely to escalate" around the summit, including cyber-kinetic operations on European critical infrastructure, submarine cable targeting, and AI-generated deepfakes designed to sow doubt about alliance unity. The report recommended "last-mile cyber hygiene around summit infrastructure, pre-emptive takedowns of spoofed domains and synthetic news clips, and rapid transparent debunks to emerging non-credible reporting" — alongside continuous liaison between NATO StratCom, CERTs, and intelligence partners.^{[4][5]}

The G7 Rapid Response Mechanism (RRM), established in 2018, plays a coordinating role for state-sponsored disinformation and FIMI responses among liberal democracies. The US CISA (Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency) has published guidance on hybrid threat taxonomies and the defensive integration of cyber and information security functions. The UN Global Digital Compact commits member states to information integrity principles, which the Accra Declaration explicitly references as a foundation for African responses.^{[1][3]}

The EU Digital Services Act (DSA), fully applicable from February 2024, creates the world's most comprehensive regulatory framework for platform accountability on illegal and harmful content. Very Large Online Platforms (VLOPs) — including Meta, X/Twitter, TikTok, Google, and YouTube — are required to conduct systemic risk assessments, implement mitigation measures, and submit to independent audit and European Commission enforcement. The European Commission has opened formal investigations into X/Twitter and TikTok for non-compliance with DSA disinformation provisions. The EU's Code of Practice on Disinformation was reinforced in 2022 and revised in 2024 as a co-regulatory instrument under the DSA's systemic risk framework. These instruments represent the most robust legal accountability structure globally, though critics note enforcement is uneven and transparency mechanisms lack genuine independence.^{[6][7][8][9]}

The Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity (C2PA) — a cross-industry standard founded by Adobe and Microsoft — provides cryptographic "Content Credentials" as digital provenance certification for multimedia content. Leica released the first camera with Content Credentials built in; Nikon and Qualcomm (via Snapdragon8 Gen3) have followed. This emerging standard creates tamper-evident authentication of digital content at the point of

capture, enabling detection of manipulated imagery — a critical capability against deepfake operations that form the backbone of many hybrid influence campaigns. Adoption is growing but uneven, and current uptake by African media organisations is minimal.^{[10][11][12]}

Technical Countermeasures: The "Disinformation Security" Stack

Gartner designated "Disinformation Security" a top strategic technology trend for 2025, defining it as a category of technologies for ensuring integrity, assessing authenticity, preventing impersonation, and tracking the spread of disinformation. The category encompasses four pillars:^[13]

1. **Deepfake detection:** Combining generative AI and digital forensics to distinguish legitimate from synthetic content. Gartner notes that "relying on human ability to detect synthetic media even with training is rarely effective" and recommends integrating deepfake detection directly into workflows for identity verification, real-time communications, and claims validation. Vendors in this space include Reality Defender, Deep Media, Sensity, and Clarity.^[13]
2. **Impersonation prevention / continuous adaptive trust:** Moving beyond multi-factor authentication to continuous risk-based scoring throughout user sessions, flagging anomalous behaviour that indicates account takeover (ATO). Business Email Compromise remains the top financial loss vector — representing only 2.4% of internet crime cases in 2023 but accounting for \$2.9 billion in losses. ATO enables social engineering attacks at scale, including the infamous Hong Kong case where a finance worker was deceived into transferring \$25 million via a deepfake video call with a fake CFO.^[13]
3. **Narrative intelligence (NI):** Large language model-powered monitoring systems that track narratives across social media, mainstream media, dark web, and semi-closed messaging environments. Unlike conventional social media monitoring (which tracks volume and sentiment), NI identifies: who is building a narrative, why it is gaining traction, whether it is organic or coordinated, and where it is headed. Gartner found that 79% of enterprises have encountered misinformation, disinformation, or malinformation (MDM) issues in the last three years, but only 14% of CCOs intend to invest in NI tools by 2027 — a "significant lack of awareness". Gartner projects that by 2029, 45% of CCOs will adopt NI tools. Representative vendors include Blackbird.AI, Cyabra, Alethea, Alto Intelligence, and PeakMetrics.^{[14][15]}
4. **Reputation and brand protection:** Proactively identifying harmful narratives targeting an organisation, executive team, or product — and their source, propagation pathway, and velocity — to enable a pre-emptive response before crisis escalation. The WEF estimates fake news costs companies approximately \$39 billion in annual stock market losses.^[15]
^[13]

Alto Intelligence, named as a vendor of reference in Gartner's February 2026 NI report, describes its infrastructure as processing "over 700 billion signals annually across 50 languages and 125 countries spanning mainstream platforms, fringe forums, grey-space channels, and semi-closed messaging environments". Its framing of this as "cognitive threat intelligence" — expanding the security perimeter beyond technical systems to include the narrative environment — is analytically precise for the hybrid threat context.^[14]

Gartner's Disinformation Security report recommends a cross-functional "TrustOps" approach, requiring representatives from executive leadership, legal, public relations, marketing, sales, security, and product management — not security teams alone. This reflects a key structural insight: intrusion-based hybrid operations require a coordinated technical and communications response; neither a CISO alone nor a CCO alone is sufficient.^[13]

The Accountability Gap: When Elites Are Part of the Problem

A critical caveat applies throughout 7a: in many African countries, the political elites who should be responding to hybrid threats are themselves engaging in disinformation, co-opting platforms for domestic political manipulation, and using government powers to suppress independent media. RSF (Reporters Without Borders) documented that South Africa improved from 38th to 27th in its 2025 World Press Freedom Index, with a well-established culture of investigative journalism — but noting that political leaders and activists subject journalists to verbal attacks and smear campaigns. Across the continent, the Journal of Democracy has documented how governments are using cybercrime laws and digital security regulations as tools to suppress independent journalism and criminalise fact-checkers.^{[16][17]}

In this context, independent oversight and transparency mechanisms become essential countermeasures in their own right. The DSA enforcement model — European Commission as independent enforcer, with regular public transparency reports from platforms — provides a template that African regional bodies could adapt, though significant institutional capacity-building is required. The Accra Declaration explicitly calls for laws and policies to protect fact-checkers and journalists from intimidation, and establishes reporting mechanisms for online and offline threats. Where governments are part of the disinformation ecosystem, civil society and independent media must be treated as primary resilience actors, not auxiliary ones.^[1]

Broader Definition: Responses to Pure Influence Operations (No Intrusion)

Pure influence operations — Coordinated Inauthentic Behaviour (CIB), state-sponsored narratives amplified through fake accounts, disinformation-as-a-service, election interference through social media — require different response mechanisms because there is no cyber intrusion to detect or attribute.

Platform Governance and the DSA Model

The EU's DSA creates the most robust global accountability structure for platform responses to disinformation-enabled influence operations. Its requirements for VLOPs include: risk assessments for electoral and societal harms; access to algorithmic recommendation systems for researchers; mandatory transparency reporting; and emergency protocols that can require expedited content moderation during crises. The Commission's enforcement action against TikTok and X has tested these provisions, with X challenging the Commission's interpretation of its systemic risk obligations. A key structural weakness identified by academic reviewers is that the DSA relies heavily on platforms self-reporting, and independent oversight mechanisms lack sufficient enforcement power.^{[7][8][9][6]}

For Africa, there is no equivalent continental regulatory framework. The African Union Convention on Cybersecurity and Personal Data Protection (Malabo Convention, 2014) has been ratified by only 14 of 55 AU member states and does not address disinformation specifically. The AU Continental Framework on Information Integrity, Digital, Media, and Information Literacy (MIL) is under active development as a joint AU-UNESCO initiative (consultations completed in 2025, first draft presented to AU Commission). UNESCO's African Guidelines for Ensuring Information Integrity on Tech Platforms — developed through multi-stakeholder consultations in 2025 across the continent — are being finalized for presentation to the ACHPR (African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights). These will provide standards for African states to monitor platforms' fact-checking responsibilities and public interest obligations.^{[18][19][20][21][^22]}

UNESCO's September 2025 Regional Conference on Information Integrity in West Africa and the Sahel led to the adoption of a Model Policy on Information Integrity and a framework for digital platform governance in West Africa. Research ICT Africa's parallel initiative to develop a model policy framework for West African states aligned with UNESCO guidelines specifically addresses the challenge of varying digital development levels across the 15 ECOWAS states. ECOWAS itself convened journalist training programmes in Cabo Verde (January 2026) and Togo (October 2025) focused on information integrity and countering disinformation.^{[23][24][25][26][^27]}

The G7 Rapid Response Mechanism provides a model for rapid intergovernmental coordination against state-sponsored influence operations. An African equivalent does not yet exist, though the AU Peace and Security Council's January 2024 African Common Position on the Application of International Law to ICTs in Cyberspace provides a foundation for coordinated state responses.^{[3][18]}

The EEAS Deterrence Approach: From Diagnosis to Impact

The EEAS 4th FIMI Report's most significant strategic contribution is the "FIMI Deterrence Playbook" — shifting from identifying and labelling incidents to actively disrupting the operational infrastructure that sustains them. By mapping the "Galaxy of FIMI operations" — the network of digital channels functioning as the operational backbone, linked to regional hubs targeting Sub-Saharan Africa, MENA, Moldova, and Armenia — the EEAS can identify critical nodes: hosting providers, advertising networks, and proxy operators. These can then be targeted through sanctions (the EU has sanctioned Russian individuals for disinformation activities), law enforcement (Europol and Eurojust can pursue criminal liability), regulatory action (DSA enforcement), and platform takedowns coordinated with Meta, Google, and others.^{[2][28][^29]}

The deterrence approach has an inherent limitation in the African context: it requires significant institutional capacity, cross-border intelligence sharing, and political will to act against allied state actors — capacities that are nascent rather than mature across most of Sub-Saharan Africa.

Part 7b: Responses to Information Manipulation Causing Real Harm to Ordinary Africans

The 2x2 Matrix Framework

The response landscape for information harm to ordinary Africans is best understood through a two-dimensional matrix. The first dimension — **Elite vs. Ordinary** — distinguishes between institutional responses (government, corporations, multilaterals) and community-level responses (community leaders, faith leaders, families, peer networks). The second dimension — **High Information Access (HIA) vs. Low Information Access (LIA)** — captures the degree to which digital countermeasures can reach the intended audience.

High Information Access (HIA) environments are characterised by: internet penetration above ~50%; a reasonably free and independent media environment (RSF Freedom Index: "free" or "partially free"); moderate to high media literacy; and a functioning institutional framework for content moderation and fact-checking. In Africa, countries approximating HIA conditions include South Africa, Kenya, Nigeria (urban), Ghana, and Botswana.

Low Information Access (LIA) environments are characterised by: internet penetration below 30%; fragile, restricted, or captured media ecosystems (RSF: "not free" or "partially free" with significant pressure); low media literacy; and limited reach of fact-checking infrastructure. This describes much of the DRC, South Sudan, Ethiopia (rural), Mali, Niger, and Chad — precisely the environments where health disinformation and conflict-triggering rumours cause the most deaths.

The matrix generates four cells of practical response, each requiring a different mix of actors, tools, and timelines:

	Elite-Level Response	Ordinary/Community-Level Response
High Information Access (HIA)	Cell A: Digital disinformation security; NI platforms; DSA-style regulation; independent fact-checking; court injunctions against hate speech	Cell B: Media and digital literacy curricula; social media-based prebunking; peer-to-peer verification tools; influencer partnerships; community reporting hotlines
Low Information Access (LIA)	Cell C: AU/ECOWAS regional frameworks; offline journalist training; national cybercrime enforcement (with press freedom safeguards); radio broadcaster accountability	Cell D: Faith leader and community elder engagement; community radio corrections; school-based oral media literacy; household-level scam resilience training; health worker trusted-messenger networks

This matrix is neither prescriptive nor exhaustive, but it surfaces the key analytical insight: the interventions most frequently discussed in global north policy circles — platform regulation, NI tools, AI detection, DSA enforcement — operate primarily in Cell A and have limited purchase in Cells C and D. The interventions with the greatest potential impact on lives at risk in Africa are concentrated in Cells C and D.

Cell A: Elite Responses in High-Information-Access Environments

Platform accountability and regulation. In HIA countries, the most impactful institutional response is creating legally enforceable obligations on platforms to moderate harmful content — hate speech, CIB, health disinformation — in local languages. The DSA provides the global template, but Africa's platform governance is fractured. South Africa's DCDT (Department of Communications and Digital Technologies) has published a National Data and Cloud Policy (June 2024) including cybersecurity measures, but there is no equivalent to the DSA. UNESCO's consultations toward African Guidelines for platform accountability in information integrity are the most concrete multilateral process in progress. South Africa, Kenya, Nigeria, and Ghana — as the continent's largest digital economies — should be the primary advocates for adopting these guidelines as binding national standards.^{[19][30][^31]}

Independent fact-checking and media support. In HIA environments, a funded, independent fact-checking ecosystem is the single most cost-effective institutional response. Africa Check (covering English-speaking Africa), PesaCheck (East Africa), AfricaCheck's French-language operation, and CrossCheck Nigeria represent the core of this ecosystem. The Accra Declaration calls explicitly for governments and technology platforms to resource these organisations, noting that "financial constraints are a persistent issue for fact-checkers and information resilience workers, limiting the scope of their operations and their ability to reach underserved communities". Meta's fact-checking partnership programme provides limited revenue to accredited fact-checkers, but the company's December 2024 decision to discontinue third-party fact-checking in the US — with the risk this signals a global policy shift — threatens this revenue stream for African fact-checkers.^{[1][13]}

Court-enforced accountability. In South Africa, the courts have proven to be an effective — though slow — instrument against institutionalised hate speech. The Johannesburg High Court injunction against Operation Dudula for incitement of violence and hate speech against migrants (confirmed 2025) illustrates that judicial tools can constrain the most egregious hate speech actors when civil society litigates actively. This requires: an independent judiciary; active NGO/civil society litigants; and sufficient evidence documentation — preconditions that are not universally met across the continent.^[^32]

Financial fraud prevention (technical). South Africa's GSMA Scam Signal initiative — launched October 2025, making South Africa only the second country globally after the UK to deploy this real-time APP fraud detection system — represents a model for HIA Cell A responses to financial information manipulation. Scam Signal combines real-time telephony network data with banking transaction data via APIs to detect social engineering scams as they unfold — reducing scam victims by up to 41% in UK deployment. The initiative required coordination between major banks, MTN Chenosis, FICO, Jersey Telecom, the GSMA, and the South African Banking Risk Information Centre (SABRIC).^{[33][34]}

Cell B: Community-Level Responses in High-Information-Access Environments

Media and information literacy (MIL) for connected populations. For urban, educated, digitally connected Africans, evidence-based MIL interventions can demonstrably improve ability to identify false information. The Accra Declaration commits the Africa Facts Network to "developing targeted media literacy programmes, often using social media influencers and engaging content like short videos to raise awareness among youth". UNESCO's ACHPR Resolution 630 process is developing specific guidelines for independent fact-checking standards on platforms operating in Africa. The most promising innovations are "prebunking" approaches — inoculating against disinformation by explaining manipulation techniques before exposure, rather than fact-checking after — which have shown stronger effects than corrections.^{[22][35][^1]}

Online harm reporting mechanisms and platform escalation. In HIA environments, civil society organisations can partner with platforms to establish rapid-response escalation channels for harmful content. WhatsApp's partnership with Africa Check to allow users to forward suspicious messages for fact-checking (operating in South Africa and Kenya) represents this approach. However, the Accra Declaration notes that "partnerships with technology platforms still face delays and inefficiencies in removing harmful or false content, affecting the ability to promote information hygiene in real time".^[^1]

Scam resilience for ordinary consumers. The GSMA Scam Signal deployment is a Cell A initiative; the corresponding Cell B intervention is consumer scam awareness — training ordinary people to recognise social engineering tactics. South Africa's 77% scam encounter rate in 2025 makes this a mass-scale public education priority.^[^36]

Cell C: Elite Responses in Low-Information-Access Environments

Regional frameworks and norms-building. In LIA environments, national-level digital regulation is often impossible or counterproductive (where governments are themselves disinformation actors). Regional frameworks provide a level of accountability that transcends captured national institutions. The UNESCO Model Policy Framework for Information Integrity in West Africa and the Sahel (adopted September 2025) provides specific governance standards for elections and crises. ECOWAS's journalist training programme across Francophone West Africa is building the human capital for future information integrity work. The AU's Continental MIL Framework, when finalised, will provide a continental normative basis for demanding platform accountability across all 55 member states.^{[20][25][26][23]}

Radio broadcaster accountability. In LIA environments, community and national radio remains the dominant information medium — and the primary amplifier of online disinformation into offline communities. Jamie Hitchen's analysis of the Malicontext documents how a tweet read by 10% of the population can reach 100% through radio. Radio stations that broadcast unverified disinformation — whether out of political complicity, commercial incentive, or incapacity — cause measurable deaths. Accountability frameworks for radio broadcasters, including complaint mechanisms, rebuttal rights, and revocable licensing, are legitimate and proportionate regulatory interventions in LIA contexts, where they may be more impactful than any digital intervention.^[^37]

Health communication infrastructure. WHO's Africa Infodemic Response Alliance (IRA) hotline — which surged from 3,000 to over 31,000 calls in its first year of operation in the DRC — demonstrates the feasibility of building real-time health misinformation response infrastructure in LIA conflict environments. The IRA model, which combines a hotline for rumour reporting with rapid-response public communication and coordination with local health authorities, health workers, and faith leaders, addresses the specific danger of disease rumours triggering violence. Scaling this model across conflict-affected countries in Central and East Africa is a concrete, actionable response to one of the continent's deadliest information harms.^[38]

Protecting fact-checkers and health workers. The IRA documented in 2025 that four health workers were killed by mobs acting on disinformation — and this is not an isolated incident. Protecting fact-checkers and health workers from targeted violence requires: physical security measures; rapid official rebuttals of false rumours targeting them; legal accountability for incitement; and pre-positioning of trusted community voices to defend the credibility of health workers before a rumour crisis emerges. The Accra Declaration's call for laws and rapid-response mechanisms to protect fact-checkers from intimidation reflects this need.^{[38][1]}

Donor coordination and sustainable funding. The disinformation resilience ecosystem in Africa — fact-checkers, community radio networks, digital literacy NGOs, health communication specialists — is dependent on donor funding, which is fragile and often short-term. A critical institutional challenge is creating sustainable funding models: the Accra Declaration calls for platforms, governments, regional institutions, and multilateral donors to co-fund this ecosystem on a sustained basis. The abrupt loss of USAID funding in early 2025 (following executive order by the Trump administration) has severely impacted fact-checking and media literacy programmes across sub-Saharan Africa, creating an acute funding gap that neither African governments nor other donors have yet filled.^[1]

Cell D: Community-Level Responses in Low-Information-Access Environments

This cell is the most under-resourced and under-researched — and the one with the highest potential impact per dollar invested. It requires reaching people who are not online, in languages that fact-checking tools do not cover, through social networks that disinformation exploits with precision.

Engaging faith leaders as trusted messengers. The single most documented effective intervention against health disinformation in LIA Africa is the engagement of religious leaders as pro-health communicators. UNAIDS and PEPFAR's 2023 Compendium documents 41 promising practices from faith community HIV interventions, including Zambia's congregation-based HIV testing (finding children positive at 15% vs 7% for non-faith-based sites) and Nigeria's Baby Shower model (93% HIV testing linkage among pregnant women). Johns Hopkins Breakthrough ACTION's engagement of 144 Christian and Muslim leaders in Malawi for COVID-19 vaccination produced measurable improvements in uptake; the same programme operated in Nigeria and Liberia. The WHO EPI-WIN Communities of Practice for faith partners, established in 2020, provides a global coordination structure for this work.^{[39][40][41]}

The principle generalises beyond HIV and COVID: faith leaders who circulate harmful false information about health, gender, or inter-communal conflict cause deaths; faith leaders equipped with accurate information and genuine pastoral motivation to share it prevent deaths. Systematic pre-positioning of faith leaders — briefing them before a health emergency, an election, or a period of heightened communal tension — is cost-effective, scalable, and leverages existing institutional trust. This is not an emergency measure but a preventive infrastructure investment.

Community information resilience labs (offline tool-kits). The Accra Declaration recommends "community information resilience labs, offline information integrity manuals, and collaboration with technology platforms and telecommunications companies to lower data costs" as tools for populations with limited connectivity. Several African civil society organisations have piloted offline fact-checking resource kits — printed or audio materials — deployed through schools, clinics, and community centres. The challenge is keeping these materials current as disinformation evolves rapidly.^[22]^[1]

Indigenous language and oral media literacy. The Accra Declaration identifies linguistic diversity as a structural vulnerability: "the peddlers of harmful falsehoods exploit the immediacy and potency of local languages to mislead the public at a time when many fact-checking tools and resources are not available in local languages". UNESCO's FIFAfrica25 consultation specifically addressed "how to shift the paradigm from viewing local and indigenous languages as a challenge for platforms to recognising them as a critical asset for building a safer and more inclusive internet for all". Practical responses include: training community radio presenters in local languages on verification techniques; developing visual (not text-dependent) media literacy resources in local visual vocabularies; and working with traditional oral media systems — praise singers, village storytellers, community criers — to spread counter-narratives.^[22]^[1]

Scam resilience at household level. Investment fraud, romance scams, and fake job advertisements prey on economic desperation in both HIA and LIA environments, but in LIA contexts, victims have fewer reporting channels and recovery mechanisms. Community-level scam resilience training — delivered through schools, community centres, and churches/mosques — using simple, memorable heuristics ("if it sounds too good to be true, it is") adapted to local scam types is demonstrably effective. South Africa's scam awareness campaigns by the Banking Association (BASA) and SABRIC operate primarily through digital channels; in LIA contexts, equivalent content needs to reach communities through radio jingles, community meetings, and word of mouth.

Peer-to-peer health communication networks. In conflict-affected LIA contexts, the WHO IRA hotline model can be complemented by trained community health workers who can conduct "rapid rumour assessment" when a new false narrative emerges — triangulating what community members are hearing, identifying the most trusted local sources to rebut it, and escalating to health authorities where the rumour poses imminent risk. This is a human intelligence function, not a technology function, but it can be integrated with digital monitoring tools where connectivity permits.

Synthesis: The "No-One-Size-Fits-All" Design Principle in Practice

The 2×2 matrix makes explicit what the research analysis implies throughout: different cells require different actors, different tools, different timescales, and different measures of success.

- **Cell A (Elite, HIA):** Best suited for technical tools (NI platforms, deepfake detection, Scam Signal), legal tools (court injunctions, platform regulation, DSA-modelled frameworks), and independent institutional oversight (fact-checking, press freedom protection). Success measured in: platform takedowns, criminal prosecutions, fraud prevention rates, fact-check reach.
- **Cell B (Community, HIA):** Best suited for MIL education programmes, youth-oriented digital literacy, social media prebunking, influencer partnerships, community reporting tools. Success measured in: verified information sharing rates, willingness to fact-check before forwarding, recognition of common manipulation techniques.
- **Cell C (Elite, LIA):** Best suited for regional normative frameworks (AU/ECOWAS), radio broadcaster accountability, WHO-model health communication infrastructure, fact-checker protection laws, and international donor coordination. Success measured in: ratification rates, enforcement actions, fact-checker security incidents, health worker attack rates.
- **Cell D (Community, LIA):** Best suited for faith leader engagement, oral/visual media literacy, community radio fact-checking, indigenous language resources, household scam resilience training, and peer-to-peer health communication networks. Success measured in: vaccination uptake, violence incidents attributable to rumours, health worker safety, scam loss rates in target communities.

A unifying principle across all four cells is **multi-stakeholder coordination** — explicitly articulated in the Accra Declaration's commitment to "build and expand meaningful coalitions with all information resilience players, the civil society, responsive governments, technology platforms, regional, global and multilateral institutions, and engage communities". The most effective responses observed in the research involve actors from at least three of these categories working in concert: the IRA model (WHO + government health authorities + community leaders + fact-checkers); the Scam Signal model (GSMA + mobile operators + banks + SABRIC); the Breakthrough ACTION faith-leader model (Ministry of Health + international NGO + religious institutions); and the DSA enforcement model (European Commission + civil society + platforms + researchers).^[1]

Cross-Cutting Recommendations for Security Leaders

The following practical steps span the Elite/HIA context most relevant to ITWeb Security Summit attendees:

For CISOs/CIOs (technical defence of hybrid intrusion-based operations):

1. Implement continuous adaptive trust models beyond MFA — continuous risk-based session scoring to prevent ATO-enabled social engineering.^[13]

2. Integrate deepfake detection into identity verification, real-time communications, and claims validation workflows — do not rely on human detection.[¹³]
3. Adopt NIST CSF 2.0 and SP 800-61 Rev. 3 (April 2025) incident response frameworks — particularly the expanded "shared responsibility" model requiring legal, PR, HR, and executive involvement.[⁴²][⁴³]
4. Use MISP/STIX-formatted threat intelligence sharing through ISACs and national CERTs to share indicators of hybrid operations across the sector.[⁴⁴][⁴⁵]
5. Establish playbooks specifically for ransomware-as-influence operations — where the extortion threat is used to amplify reputational damage alongside the financial demand. [¹³]

For CCOs/CMOs (narrative and reputation protection):

1. Deploy Narrative Intelligence tools alongside — not instead of — traditional social media monitoring: NI provides pre-crisis detection; monitoring alone provides post-crisis measurement.[¹⁵]
2. Build a cross-functional TrustOps team: the disinformation threat requires legal, PR, marketing, security, and executive engagement simultaneously.[¹³]
3. Use Gartner's five self-assessment criteria to evaluate urgency of NI investment: susceptibility to truth decay, stakeholder ecosystem complexity, digital attack surface size, cost of inaction, and current capability gap.[¹⁴][¹⁵]
4. For organisations operating in southern/eastern Africa: ensure NI tools have coverage in local languages (Zulu, Afrikaans, Swahili, Amharic) and semi-closed WhatsApp/Telegram ecosystems — not just English-language public social media.[¹⁴]
5. Engage C2PA and Content Credentials adoption in any media-production workflow to establish provenance for communications materials that could be targeted for synthetic manipulation.[¹¹][¹⁰]

For government and civil society actors (structural resilience):

1. Resource and protect independent fact-checkers as critical information infrastructure — including secure communications tools, legal defence funds, and rapid-response coordination with platforms.[¹]
2. Advocate for AU/ECOWAS adoption of the UNESCO Model Policy on Information Integrity and the AU Continental MIL Framework as continent-wide platform accountability standards.[²⁵][²⁰]
3. Pre-position faith community partnerships for health emergency communication before the next crisis — not during it. Document and share promising practices (UNAIDS/PEPFAR Compendium model).[⁴⁰][³⁹]
4. Invest in WHO-IRA-model rumour monitoring and rapid-response health communication infrastructure in conflict-affected and LIA environments.[³⁸]
5. Ensure any new national cybersecurity legislation or disinformation regulation includes press freedom safeguards and independent oversight mechanisms — recognising that governments are sometimes part of the problem, not the solution.[¹⁷][¹⁶]

This report draws on: the attached Gartner Disinformation Security report (October 2024); Gartner CCO Narrative Intelligence report (February 2026); Alto Intelligence Gartner Reference document (2026); Accra Declaration on Information Integrity and Resilience in Africa (October 2024); EEAS 4th Annual FIMI Threat Report (March 2026); EU Digital Services Act analysis; UNESCO African Guidelines consultations; ECOWAS information integrity initiatives; GSMA Scam Signal documentation; UNAIDS/Breakthrough ACTION faith leader research; C2PA/Content Authenticity Initiative; NIST SP 800-61 Rev. 3 (April 2025); NATO/Recorded Future hybrid threat assessments; and prior reports in this series on incident taxonomy, drivers, and real-world harm to ordinary Africans. ^{[8][9][5][24][43][34][29][4][6][23][19][20][25][39][40][10][11][2][33][15][14][13][^1]}

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